

Swanzey Town Administrator — Interview Kit

Talking points · anticipated questions · STAR stories · first-100-days · the numbers to
have cold

Private interview-prep · v0.1 · June 2026

Built on the Swanzey financial, capital, and voting analysis

Personal working document — edit the [bracketed] items with your own specifics

1. How to use this — and the tone that wins

You know this town's numbers better than almost anyone who will sit across from you. That is your edge — and your trap. Used well it says 'prepared.' Used badly it says 'presumptuous.' Three rules keep you on the right side of that line.

1. **Lead with homework and humility, not critique.** Say 'I spent time with your annual reports and here's what I learned,' never 'here's what you did wrong.' Credit the board's discipline first; let them pull the harder diagnosis out of you.
2. **Bring the two-pager, never the eleven-pager.** Carry the 2-Page Summary as a leave-behind only if asked. Reciting a critique of their record before you're hired backfires, however gracious.
3. **Always bridge findings to leadership.** Every answer ends with how you would lead, not just what you found. They are hiring a person, not a report.

Three reflexes to repeat until they're automatic: (1) I serve the board as a body, by majority vote — not any one member. (2) No surprises — ever. (3) I bring options and a recommendation, not problems.

2. Your 90-second open

For 'tell us about yourself' / 'why this role.' Make it personal, then pivot to Swanzey. Fill the brackets in your own words; keep it under two minutes.

[One line on who you are and the through-line of your work.] I'm drawn to this role because the work I care about is making local government effective and trustworthy — and Swanzey is at a real inflection point. You have rising needs, a water system you've just taken on, and a public-works facility that keeps falling just short of the bond threshold. I did my homework: I can walk you through the town's fifteen-year budget and voting record, and I think there's a fundable, low-drama path through it. What this town needs first isn't another resume — it's continuity and a credible plan. [One line on why you'll provide both, with a concrete example.]

3. The 'why you' questions (close the credibility gap)

Q. “You've never held a Town Administrator title. Why you?”

Two things. First, I've done the homework — I can tell you this town's budget and voting record cold, so I'd contribute on day one, not month six. Second, the job isn't a title; it's making the board's authority effective and the town's services reliable. [Here's where I've done exactly that: .] Swanzey doesn't need a veteran resume right now as much as it needs continuity and a plan to fund what keeps failing — I have the plan, and I intend to stay to deliver it.

Q. “We've had three administrators in two years. How do we know you'll stay?”

That's the most important question in this search, and I'd want the same commitment in return: a multi-year agreement, a written annual evaluation against goals we set together, and clear lanes between the board's policy role and my administrative one. Turnover usually isn't about people — it's about ambiguity and friction. Remove those and continuity follows. I'm looking for somewhere to build over years, not a stepping stone.

Q. “Why should we hire you over a more experienced candidate?”

Experience matters, and I respect it. But experience without preparation still spends six months learning the town. I've already learned it. Pair that with [your relevant strengths], and you get someone who starts adding value immediately and is hungry to prove the board made the right call.

4. Anticipated questions — Swanzey-specific

Q. What's the biggest challenge facing the town?

Continuity. The needs are rising — a water utility, a public-works facility, aging plant — and the town has steered through a lot of administrator turnover. The good news: the hard analysis is done and a financing path exists. The challenge is execution over several years, which is exactly what stable administration provides.

Q. The public works facility failed twice. What would you do?

It didn't fail on the merits — it won majorities both times and fell short of the three-fifths a bond needs. So I wouldn't run it as a bond a third time. I'd establish a Public Works Facility capital reserve — a simple-majority vote — and fund it on a published CIP, pay-as-you-go, building it around 2031 with no bond and no 3/5 hurdle. The record is clear: this town will save; it won't borrow. Meet it where it is.

Q. A resident is upset their bill rose even though the 2024 rate dropped.

That's the revaluation. Bill equals value times rate over a thousand — in 2024 assessed values rose, so the rate fell from about \$26.87 to \$19.06, but bills didn't fall to match. I'd put a one-page explainer in every tax envelope, because that confusion costs trust the town can't afford — and remind folks ~60% of the bill is school and county; the municipal piece is about a quarter.

Q. How would you finance the West Swanzey water system?

As an enterprise, not a tax burden. A rate study and an asset-management plan, then finance the capital through the DWSRF — a 1% loan repaid by water rates, with the principal forgiveness the town is already pursuing — so it stays off the property tax. Acquiring it was the right call; the job now is disciplined execution.

Q. How do you manage a five-member board?

More voices means more alignment up front. Clear operating norms — agenda discipline, one-voice-to-staff, conflict recusal — and I brief all five equally and early. The expansion was voters asking for more oversight; my job is to make that oversight efficient, not slower.

Q. A selectman directs a DPW employee to plow their road first.

I treat it as input, not a directive, and route it to the board as a body — I serve the majority vote, not one member. I'd raise it with the member privately, never embarrass them publicly, and make sure the crew follows the plowing policy. One-voice-to-staff protects everyone, the board included.

Q. Right-to-Know request for the fire chief's emails — what do you do?

Acknowledge within five business days under RSA 91-A. The presumption is that records are public unless we can prove an exemption, so I assemble them, analyze any personnel or investigatory exemptions with counsel, produce what's public, and document the basis for anything withheld. The law doesn't bend for how I feel about the request.

Q. How would you handle development conflict like the Avanru lawsuit?

Land-use boards have to decide on the written criteria, on the record, with counsel present — not on how loud the room is. That's both the law and the best protection against litigation. I'd support the boards with clean staff work and clear findings, and I'd review the ordinance for any ambiguity that invites disputes.

Q. Walk us through the budget and where it's headed.

It's grown about 55% since 2012 to roughly \$8.9M, now 6–7% a year — driven by health insurance, wages, retirement, and the ambulance contract, not new programs. And the default budget now nearly equals the proposal, so 'vote no to save' no longer works. I'd be honest with residents about those drivers and relentless about capturing outside money so the municipal share stays manageable.

Q. A union contract is up for negotiation.

Under RSA 273-A, I'd prepare with a clear cost model and the board's parameters, bargain in good faith, and remember cost items have to be funded by the voters — so nothing I agree to is real until it's appropriated. I'd also mind the status-quo doctrine if we go past expiration.

Q. What's the town's welfare obligation?

RSA 165 — every NH town must assist residents who can't support themselves. I'd make sure we have written guidelines, administer them fairly, and treat it as the statutory duty it is, not discretion.

5. Four STAR stories (scaffold with your own specifics)

Have these rehearsed. Situation/Task → Action → Result. Keep each under 90 seconds; land the result.

Prompt it answers	Situation / Task	Action (the point)	Result
Delivering hard news to leadership	[A budget/decision with bad news for a board or boss]	Brought options + a recommendation; no surprises; framed the tradeoffs honestly	[Decision made; trust intact]
Turning around a stalled effort	[An initiative that kept failing — your 'public works facility']	Diagnosed WHY it failed (structure, not will) and re-approached	[It passed / got delivered]
A hard personnel situation	[A performance or conduct issue]	Documented, followed policy and due process, kept the person's dignity, used counsel	[Resolved without litigation; policy improved]
Building a system from nothing	[A missing process — purchasing, records, onboarding]	Installed a simple, durable system others could run	[Outlived you; reduced risk/cost]

Pick real stories. If you don't have a municipal one, a comparable leadership/organizational story is fine — name the transfer explicitly: 'the dynamic is the same in a town: ...'

6. First 100 days in Swanzey (one-pager)

Days 1–30 — Listen, change nothing. 1:1s with each selectman; every department head at their site; the Town Clerk and Tax Collector (peers, likely elected — they don't report to you); town counsel; the DRA municipal contact; board/committee chairs. Read three years of minutes, the last audit, every CBA, the personnel policy, and the CIP.

Days 31–60 — Map. Document the budget calendar and every statutory deadline; who's elected vs. appointed; the open capital projects and grants; the litigation/risk register; the records and Right-to-Know posture.

Days 61–100 — One visible win + a plan. Stand up the single highest-leverage system (a published CIP draft, a Right-to-Know intake, or a tax-bill explainer), and bring the board a 90-day findings memo with a prioritized year-one plan and how you'd like to be evaluated.

The honest framing for the room: 'I won't reorganize anything in 90 days. I'll listen, map, deliver one credible win, and bring you a plan we agree on.'

7. The numbers to have cold

Topic	Have this ready
Operating budget	~\$8.94M (2026); +6.8% this year; ~6–7%/yr lately; drivers = health, wages, NHRS, ambulance
Tax rate	\$20.18 total (2025); municipal ~\$5.62; 2024 drop to \$19.06 was a REVALUATION; ed ~60% of the bill
Budget support	~80% (2011–15) → 57% (2025) — eroding
Capital pattern	reserves/credits pass 78–90%; facility bond failed 3/5 in 2024 & 2026 (681–485) — majority, not 3/5
Default budget	within ~\$47K of the proposal — the 'vote no to save' lever is gone
Water	acquired West Swanzey system (2025); TIF; DWSRF study expecting 100% principal forgiveness
Governance	SB2 since 2005; board expanded 3→5 (2025, 740–653); SB2 repeal rejected 345–809 (2026)
Calendar	deliberative session ~1st Tue Feb; ballot ~2nd Tue Mar; board meets Wed 5:30pm, Whitcomb Hall
Town	~7,270 residents; five villages; Cheshire County; Monadnock Regional schools
Key RSA	32 budget · 40:13 SB2/default · 35 reserves · 234 bridge aid (80/20) · 91-A right-to-know (5 biz days) · 33-A retention · 165 welfare · 273-A labor · 100-A NHRS · 674:5-8 CIP · 38 utilities

Before the interview, refresh the LIVE unknowns: current board members' names & priorities, the REAL MS-1 valuation (your workbook uses a placeholder), actual reserve balances, and the pending agenda. A wrong number from memory hurts more than 'I'd confirm that figure.'

8. Breadth quick-hits (don't get caught thin)

Domain	One-line ready answer	RSA
Procurement	No state statute for towns — I'd install a written local purchasing policy (thresholds, RFPs, conflicts)	local policy
Records/retention	Public unless exempt; 5-business-day response; can't delete before the retention clock	91-A, 33-A
Roads	Class I–VI determines who maintains and what aid applies; scenic-road and driveway rules	231
Emergency mgmt	Local EOP/EOC, NIMS, FEMA public assistance after a declared disaster — real on the Ashuelot	21-P
Capital planning	A rolling 6-year CIP turns surprises into expectations and underpins the reserve strategy	674:5-8
Personnel	At-will + progressive discipline + contemporaneous documentation; counsel before termination	—
Bonding (if ever)	3/5 in an SB2 town; use the Bond Bank for rates — but the plan is reserves, not bonds	33, 35-A

9. Traps to avoid — and how to close

- **Don't bring the 11-page review.** The 2-pager, and only if asked.
- **Don't critique the board's past votes.** Credit the discipline; frame the 3/5 losses as a structure problem, not a judgment problem.
- **Don't claim the elected Clerk/Tax Collector reports to you.** They don't — say you'd 'coordinate closely.'
- **Don't overpromise on taxes or speed.** 'Save first, leverage aid, no spike' — and projects take a few years.

- **Don't wing a number.** If unsure, say you'd confirm it. Precision builds trust; bluffing destroys it.

Your closing statement (have it ready)

'I'll be straight about what drew me here: this town has done the hard part — it saves, it keeps faith with voters, and it just made a smart move on water. What it needs now is someone who will stay, stabilize the office, publish a plan, and quietly go get the state's money so the projects that keep stalling finally get built — without a tax spike. That's the job I want, and it's the job I've prepared for. I'd be grateful for the chance.'

Sources behind every number: the companion Swanzey Financial Review, Capital Workbook, and Strategic Review (PublicLogic). Confirm live figures with the Town before the interview.